

Her letters to a nervous Dutt show her forever assuaging his concern about her past, her growing stature after *Mother India*'s release, and her grasping elder brother. It shows a woman almost spiralling out of control as Dutt wrestled with his own demons, attempting suicide several times when she didn't hear from him, sometimes just cutting her fingers with a blade to heighten her pain, and enduring the taunts of a brother whose lifestyle and family she financed and who had no interest or desire in seeing her settling down. Sometimes her self-pitying letters seem truly pitiful, completely at odds with her strong portrayals on screen. Desai quotes many passages such as this: "I wanted to study, but because I was a girl and had good looks, I was forced to be the earning member of the family from a very tender age."

More than that, the book shows her ultimate iron will, resisting Kapoor who pursued her much after she had walked out on him. As she writes to Dutt about a prolonged visit from Kapoor when she was in Berlin attending the international film festival: "He could never believe that things have ended. I told him this parting will be good not only for me alone but good for him, good for his wife, and very good for his children. Raj wanted to know what should he do with the money that has to be paid to me. I said I don't want it—and the land that had been bought for the house, I said I also didn't want that."

Nargis's almost brutal honesty was not always reciprocated by Dutt, who the book shows had a very firm idea of what a marriage should be. If he was the man who cut his own fingers to share her pain, he was also the struggling actor grappling with his would-be wife's rising fame and clout. If she was the Padma Shri-feted actor of *Mother India*, she was also the woman who went on a drinking binge of forgetfulness and self-destruction when Dutt threatened a break up.

It's a pity that writing on the Dutt family has become a cottage industry—Priya and Namrata Dutt's memoirs of their parents are barely a month old. But at the risk of sounding like a Nargis groupie, no one, not even the wonderful T.J.S. George appreciation, has made her sound so human.

TOP 10

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

BESTSELLERS

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
2. (2)	The Last Testament	Sam Bourne	HarperCollins
3. (8)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
4. (7)	The Reluctant Fundamentalist	Mohsin Hamid	Penguin
5. (10)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (4)	India After Gandhi: The History of the World's Largest Democracy	Ramachandra Guha	Picador
3. (5)	The Last Mughal: The Fall of a Dynasty	William Dalrymple	Penguin
4. (3)	King of Bollywood: Shah Rukh Khan	Anupama Chopra	Warner Bros
5. (16)	The Kao Boys of R&AW	B. Raman	Lancer

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
10. (-)	Q and A: A Novel	Vikas Swarup	Doubleday
12. (-)	Gifted	Nikita Lalwani	Penguin
18. (20)	My Revolutions	Hari Kunzru	Hamish Hamilton

NON-FICTION

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (8)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin
7. (-)	India 60: Towards a New Paradigm	Ira Pande	HarperCollins
8. (-)	The Indians: Portrait of a People	Sudhir Kakar and Katharina Kakar	Penguin
9. (-)	Buddha: A Story of Enlightenment	Deepak Chopra	HarperCollins

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead